Impossible Expectations for the Poor

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Background

People often view the poor through a narrow lens: their **lack of money**.

As a result, they fixate on ways the poor can address this salient need, overlooking the larger context of their lives and other challenges they face.

In short, they think the poor just need to **work *more*** and **spend *less***.

Could this lead people to hold inconsistent or impossible expectations for the poor?

Methods

STUDY 1 (*N* = 1004) - *Inconsistent* Expectations

Two-phase, between-subjects design

Phase 1 (*N* = 202): Participants read about a poor/rich person and indicated how many hours the person should work the next day (0 to 24).

Phase 2 (*N* = 802): Participants read the same vignette from P1. Then, they were either told the person had already worked for *[P1 median]* hours (control) or first asked if the person should keep going, and then told the person stopped working for the day ("stop"). After, all participants rated the worker's laziness (1 = not lazy, 7 = very lazy).

STUDY 2 (*N* = 601) - *Harsher* Judgements

2 *(worker: poor vs. rich)* x 2 *(signup: control vs. did not sign up)* between-subjects design



OR



Participants read about a poor/rich worker choosing between two mutually exclusive jobs: driving or delivery.

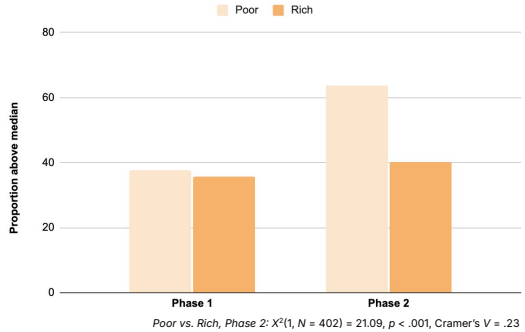
Then, they were either given no additional information regarding the worker's promotion choice (control) or told the worker did not sign up for the promotion they read ("did not sign up").

Participants then rated the worker's laziness.

Results

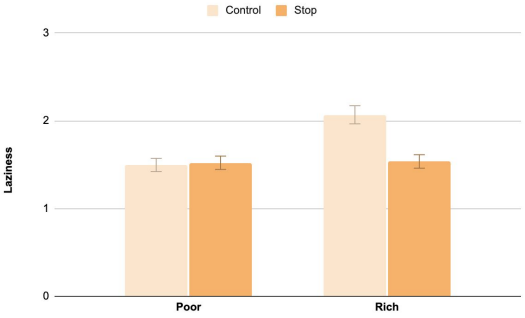
STUDY 1 | **Poor: 10 hours** | **Rich: 4 hours**

Do you think they should keep going?



Poor vs. Rich, Phase 2: $X^2(1, N = 402) = 21.09$, $p < .001$, Cramer's $V = .23$

How lazy would you say this person is?



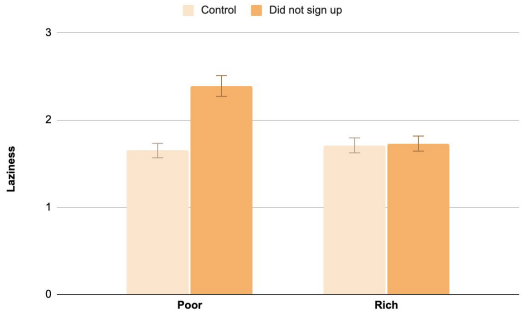
Interaction effect: $F(1, 798) = 11.66$, $p = < .001$.

Results

STUDY 2 | **Poor: 148%** | **Rich: 96%**

	Poor (%)	Rich (%)	χ^2 (df)	p-value	Cramer's *V*
Driving	84.66 (***)	51.65	36.25 (1)	< .001	0.35
Delivery	63.08 (***)	44.37	9.83 (1)	.001	0.19

(***) significantly greater than 50%, $p < .001$



Interaction effect: $F(1, 597) = 11.47$, $p = < .001$.

Conclusion

People's expectations for the poor can be inconsistent (study 1).

It is easier for people to find reasons why a poor person should work; it is harder for people to think of a reason why a poor person should stop. Standards ***shift*** when opportunities to earn are made salient.

And at times, these expectations are even impossible (study 2).

When the poor inevitably come short of these (inconsistent, impossible) expectations, they are judged harshly.